

Why small steps matter in the battle against plastic

Many of us struggle to take even the simplest steps—like avoiding single-use plastic or **segregating** waste — **essential** for **sustaining** our planet

The natural resources of the planet are a **treasure** directly impacting our environment and climate. We need to withdraw **judiciously** and invest wisely for **sustained** growth. We can **incorporate** daily practices to grow this wealth. We live in a high-rise **condominium** complex.

There was an **animated** discussion on the community WhatsApp group about a few residents feeding cows immediately outside the main exit. This causes the cattle to **assemble** when officegoers are **in a hurry** to exit. It is a **potential** traffic **hazard**.

One gentleman rightly **pointed out** that the food dumped in plastic bags was also a health hazard. A few **vehement** voices of protest were raised. For them, feeding the **bovine** was an age-old tradition. We need to think differently to **address** issues of concern.

A national **campaign** for a complete ban on single-use plastic **was** launched a few years back. Many of our smaller states have been **conscious of** the need for a long time. I travelled to Sikkim a few years back. The shopkeeper **rummaged** through his **shelves**.

He could **barely** manage a few old newspapers to **wrap** my **provisions**. Plastic bags have been banned in the state since 1998. We were also advised to bring empty bottles since packaged mineral water bottles were banned in north Sikkim. Individually we fail to be responsive to the urgent needs.

Many residents in our complex still demand plastic bags from the fruit and vegetable vendors and the grocery stores. Despite repeated instructions, many stores refuse to **do away with** single-use plastic. My wife has been carrying cloth bags for the last 15 years whenever she steps out to buy groceries or vegetables, and even to the malls. Municipal authorities in several cities have successfully implemented the management of **segregated** waste at the household level. I stayed in Indore for a couple of days a few years back. I was **intrigued** by a song following me when I stepped out for the morning walk.

I noticed people coming out of homes with garbage bags in their hands. It was the garbage collection vehicle playing the **melodious** song. The song **exhorted** residents to **segregate** waste. The song was also a **knock on the door** about the van's arrival. I had heard so much about the unique model of Indore towards a cleaner and environment-friendly city. This was the living proof.

I was surprised to notice construction and **demolition debris stacked** in front of the houses under construction or renovation. I was told that the municipal department collected waste from the doorstep and **disposed of** the same at designated sites.

All of this has not happened overnight. Someone took the first step. Others joined, to make it a mass movement. We have been struggling to implement waste **segregation** within our society for the past 8 years. The rules **mandate** it. We still manage to find reasons to justify inaction.

Even the neighbours are not doing it, segregation is **cumbersome**, the timing for waste collection does not fit into the routine, and an individual cannot make a difference, are only a few of the excuses for not doing it. The first step is the most difficult to take. We spent a couple of days recently in Alibaug. My wife is **passionate** about the **cause** and does not get **disheartened** easily.

I was surprised when she **remarked**, "It seems that we might not see a cleaner country in our lifetime!" I would remind her and others about Barack Obama's words, "We are the first generation to feel the impact of climate change and the last generation that can do something about it."

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentences indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

[Practice Exercise]

Vocabulary

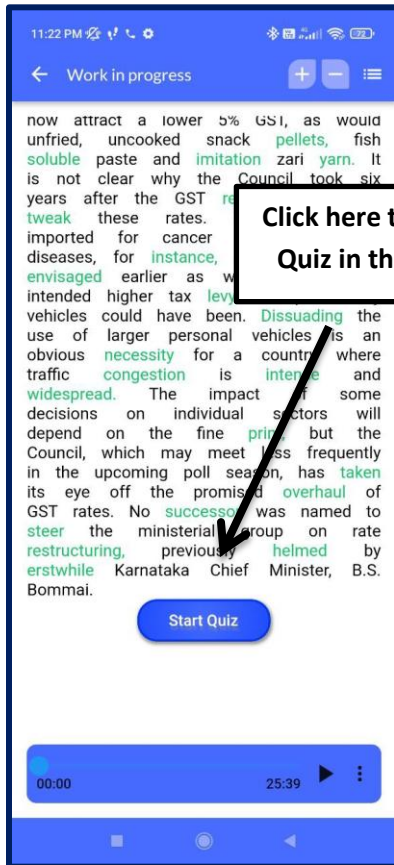
1. **Segregate** (verb) – Separate, divide, isolate, partition, split अलग करना
2. **Essential** (adjective) – Necessary, vital, crucial, indispensable, fundamental आवश्यक
3. **Sustain** (verb) – Maintain, uphold, preserve, support, continue बनाए रखना
4. **Treasure** (noun) – Wealth, riches, valuables, fortune, gems खजाना
5. **Judiciously** (adverb) – Wisely, sensibly, prudently, thoughtfully, carefully विवेकपूर्वक
6. **Sustained** (adjective) – Continuous, ongoing, prolonged, unbroken, persistent निरंतर
7. **Incorporate** (verb) – Include, integrate, merge, combine, assimilate शामिल करना
8. **Condominium** (noun) – Apartment complex, housing society, residential building, co-op, shared property आवासीय परिसर
9. **Animated** (adjective) – Lively, spirited, energetic, enthusiastic, vibrant उत्साहित
10. **Assemble** (verb) – Gather, collect, congregate, convene, muster इकट्ठा होना
11. **In a hurry** (phrase) – Rushed, hastily, quickly, in haste, hurriedly जल्दी में
12. **Potential** (adjective) – Possible, likely, prospective, latent, probable संभावित
13. **Hazard** (noun) – Danger, risk, threat, peril, jeopardy खतरा
14. **Point out** (phrasal verb) – Indicate, highlight, mention, note, draw attention to ध्यान दिलाना
15. **Vehement** (adjective) – Forceful, passionate, intense, fervent, ardent उग्र
16. **Bovine** (noun) – Cow, cattle, oxen, livestock, buffalo गाय
17. **Address** (verb) – Tackle, deal with, confront, handle, resolve समाधान करना
18. **Conscious** (of) (adjective) – Aware, mindful, cognizant, alert, attentive सचेत
19. **Rummage** (verb) – Search, scour, hunt, delve, forage खोजना
20. **Shelves** (noun) – Racks, ledges, bookcases, compartments, storage spaces अलमारियों
21. **Barely** (adverb) – Hardly, scarcely, almost not, just, narrowly मुश्किल से
22. **Wrap** (verb) – Cover, enclose, encase, envelop, package लपेटना
23. **Provision** (noun) – Supplies, necessities, groceries, foodstuffs, commodities सामान

24. **Do away with** (phrase) – Eliminate, abolish, discard, remove, get rid of समाप्त करना
25. **Segregated** (adjective) – Separated, divided, isolated, partitioned, split विभाजित
26. **Intrigued** (adjective) – Curious, interested, fascinated, captivated, engrossed जिज्ञासु
27. **Melodious** (adjective) – Harmonious, tuneful, musical, pleasant-sounding, sweet सुरीला
28. **Exhort** (verb) – Urge, encourage, implore, prompt, persuade प्रोत्साहित करना
29. **Segregate** (verb) – Separate, divide, isolate, partition, split अलग करना
30. **Knock on the door** (phrase) – Notify, alert, inform, announce, signal सूचित करना
31. **Demolition** (noun) – Destruction, dismantling, razing, tearing down, leveling विध्वंस
32. **Debris** (noun) – Rubble, wreckage, fragments, remains, litter मलबा
33. **Stack** (verb) – Pile, heap, arrange, accumulate, assemble सजाना
34. **Disposed** (of) (adjective) – Discarded, thrown away, eliminated, removed, gotten rid of निपटाया गया
35. **Segregation** (noun) – Separation, division, isolation, partition, splitting विभाजन
36. **Mandate** (verb) – Require, command, order, decree, dictate अनिवार्य करना
37. **Cumbersome** (adjective) – Awkward, unwieldy, bulky, clumsy, inconvenient भारी-भरकम
38. **Passionate** (adjective) – Enthusiastic, fervent, ardent, zealous, devoted उत्साही
39. **Cause** (noun) – Purpose, reason, motive, aim, objective कारण
40. **Disheartened** (adjective) – Discouraged, demoralized, dejected, dismayed, disappointed निराश
41. **Remark** (verb) – Comment, state, mention, observe, note टिप्पणी करना

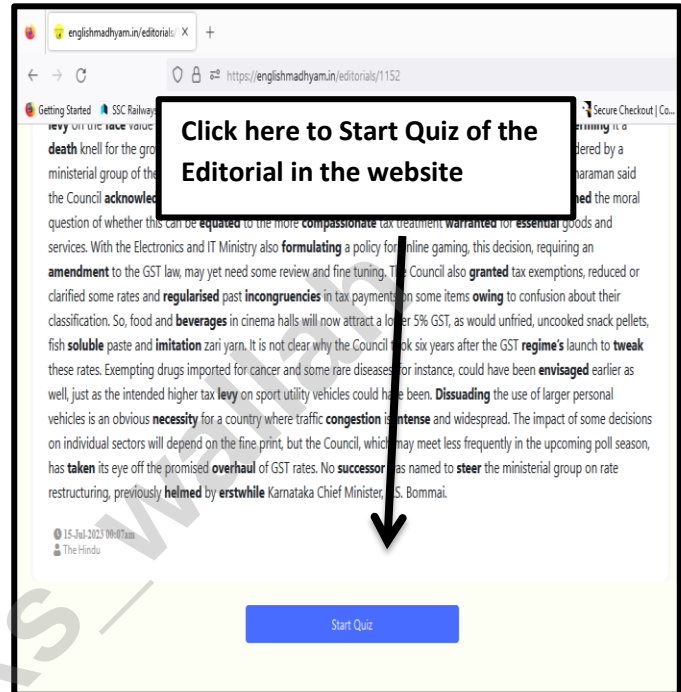
Summary of the Editorial

1. Simple actions like avoiding single-use plastics and segregating waste are crucial for environmental sustainability but are often neglected.
2. Natural resources are limited and need to be used responsibly for sustained environmental health.
3. A community debate on feeding cattle highlighted the dangers of plastic bags, which are harmful to animals.
4. Resistance to change often arises due to traditional practices, like feeding cows, which need modern reconsideration.
5. India launched a campaign to ban single-use plastics, with several smaller states adopting these practices early on.
6. Sikkim, for example, has banned plastic bags since 1998, reflecting its long-standing commitment to plastic reduction.
7. Many individuals still rely on plastic bags despite local efforts, showing a lack of responsiveness to environmental needs.
8. Examples of individuals using alternatives, like cloth bags, demonstrate personal responsibility and positive habits.
9. Some cities, like Indore, have successfully implemented waste segregation at the household level.
10. Indore's waste management system uses music in garbage collection vehicles to remind residents to segregate their waste.
11. Construction and demolition waste in Indore is also responsibly managed, with municipal pickup services at designated sites.
12. Such systemic changes result from individuals taking the first step, inspiring wider community participation.
13. Many residents still find excuses for not segregating waste, citing inconvenience and personal limitations.
14. Small actions, though challenging, are essential in the battle against plastic and environmental degradation.
15. Reflecting on Barack Obama's words, the editorial stresses that current generations have a critical responsibility to address climate change.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



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